

Filipino Women in Electoral Politics

The nature and extent of Filipino women's political participation is a product of the country's colonial history, martial law, and democratization post-1986. Historians argue that Spain's strong Catholic traditions ushered in patriarchal norms and practices that were not present in the pre-Hispanic period. National hero, Jose Rizal, has documented this in his "Letter to the Women of Malolos," praising the women for advocating their right to education. Historians also found proof of women's contribution to the Philippine revolution (Camagay 1998). Decades later, the suffragist movement ushered in one of the first national issues to have brought Filipino women together. It was a hard-fought battle; the movement had to contend with staunch opposition from antisuffragists in the Constitutional Convention that drafted the 1935 Constitution. The reluctance was expected because only 21-year-old Filipino men had been allowed to vote during the time. They framed their opposition based on traditional notions of womanhood and their role in the private sphere, foremost of which is motherhood. Another key argument against female suffrage was the idea that politics is supposed to be "dirty" and that this would taint families if women took part in politics. The assumptions catered to the age-old public-private divide, strongly suggesting that only men are qualified to occupy the former.

Eventually, the 1935 Constitution granted women suffrage on the condition that more than 300,000 women would vote affirmatively in a plebiscite. When signing the law paving the way for the said plebiscite, President Manuel Quezon had this to say to Filipino men: "Are you going to deprive our women of the opportunity to say how their lives are going to be regulated and is it fair for us to presume that men can always speak in this country for women?" (Official Gazette 1936). In April 1937, more than 400,000 women voted in favor of their right to vote and participate in political life. In 1946 and 1947, Filipinos elected the first woman member of the House of Representatives, and senator, respectively. Nonetheless, data from 1946 to 1992 indicate an uphill climb. For instance, in the 1949 and 1953 elections for the House of Representatives, only one woman was elected out of the 100 positions.